



Mantua The mantua was a style left over from the end of the 17th century, and by this date was only worn at the most formal occasions. Technically the mantua is the bodice, but the term is also used for the style of dress.



English court This ribbed silk mantua embroidered with over 5 kg (11 lb) of silver metal thread was worn at the court of King George II in Britain. Side hoops, which gave this exaggerated rectangular shape, were introduced as court dress in the 1740s.



Parading wealth France and England boasted the finest professional embroidery workshops. In the 18th century, dress was a way of parading wealth – everybody knew that your family was rich and important if you wore a costly mantua such as this one.



Transitional style By the 1750s formal fashions were changing and the draped style of the mantua was replaced by a bodice, which had only a hanging pleated flap from waist to hem. This was the forerunner to the court train.



Hand-painted Chinese silk Robes and petticoats made from painted silk were all the rage in the 1760s and 1770s. Heavily patterned, woven dress silks were going out of fashion to be replaced in part by painted and printed fabrics imported from China and India.



Sack back Originally a nightgown style, the French *sacque* (sack back) became the most fashionable and graceful dress style in mid-18th century England. The double pleats falling from the shoulders gave the distinctive triangular shape.